

Using Open Source Software on Windows

Sometimes, for compelling reasons, one is forced to work on proprietary software like Microsoft Windows. Even then, one can take advantage of open source software designed for Windows. In this article, the author describes various software that can be installed on Windows, along with a few tips on how to use these effectively.

The site www.netmarketshare.com displays the current break-up of the desktop operating systems' market for July 2015 (Figure 1). At the outset, it's important to acknowledge the problems related to software, which are always the same. On my computer at home, I have the freedom to install my preferred GNU Linux distro, but if I work at a company, I'm forced to use Windows, which is so prevalent across enterprises. Generally speaking, at home, I can also use Windows, usually pre-installed, as a base on which it is possible to add free and open source software. The software shown in Table 1 can be classified, more or less, into the following three categories:

1. Free and open source
2. Free (or free for personal use only) but not open source
3. Commercial (only one: FaxTalk)

With the only exception of FaxTalk (in my opinion, nice and cheap), for personal use, the cost of using either of the above is equal to zero. This article will present some tips and tricks tested on Windows 7 and related to the software that is highlighted in bold in Table 1.

7-Zip	JRE • JDK
Acrobat Reader	Lazarus • NetBeans • Winpython
CDBurnerXP	LibreOffice
Emacs • jEdit • Notepad++ • Vim	Printer drivers
FaxTalk	RedMon
Firefox	Scanner driver
Flash Player	Scilab
GhostScript	ShellExView
GIMP	Silverlight
ImageMagick	Skype
Inkscape	System Utilities
Internet Security	Thunderbird
IrfanView	VLC

Table 1: Software for installation on Windows 7

Text editors

The importance of a text editor is well known. On Windows, a long list of text editors is available. This section describes how to build a syntax highlighting file for jEdit (<http://jedit>).